Walk in the Spirit

Christian liberty is not freedom to indulge the flesh but freedom to walk continually in step with the Holy Spirit — who alone produces, as fruit rather than forced works, what the law could only demand.

Source: Dr. C. Norman Sellers, ThD · SellersBibleInstitute.com · used by permission

Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 The Ground of Liberty	**02** 1:6–10 The One True Gospel	**03** 1:11–17 Paul's Independent Revelation	**04** 1:18–2:10 Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches
05 2:11–21 Peter Goes Back to School	**06** 3:1–5 Under a Spell	**07** 3:6–14 Blessing or a Curse	**08** 3:15–29 The Superiority of the Promise to the Law
09 4:1–11 When I Became a Man	**10** 4:12–20 A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove	**11** 4:21–31 Paul's Old Testament Story	**12** 5:1–12 Taking a Stand in Liberty
13 5:13–26 Walk in the Spirit	**14** 6:1–5 Brothers and Burdens	**15** 6:6–10 Sowing and Reaping	**16** 6:11–18 Teaching the Truth

Three things to do with liberty

Galatians 5:13–15 · Outline I — The potential of liberty

A Exploit it through license

ἀφορμή · v.13a
Don't turn liberty into a staging ground for the flesh

B Explore it through love

δουλεύετε · v.13b–14
Through love serve one another — the law fulfilled in one word (πεπλήρωται)

C Enjoy it through harmony

v.15
Don't bite and devour one another — written to believers

Positionally we are already free (5:1). Experientially we choose, day by day, to live up to that position.

Walk, conflict, led

Galatians 5:16–18 · Outline II — The performance of liberty

The command	The conflict	The call
περιπατεῖτε “Walk in the Spirit, and you shall not fulfill the lust of the flesh”	Flesh and Spirit are contrary — a war within the believer	“If you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law”
v.16	*v.17*	*v.18*

Walking in the Spirit, not self-effort, is how the believer overcomes the flesh.

Works of the flesh, fruit of the Spirit

Galatians 5:19–23 · Outline III — The pictures of liberty

Works of the flesh — plural, self-produced
ἔργα τῆς σαρκός v.19

Sexual adultery, fornication, uncleanness, lewdness

Spiritual idolatry, sorcery

Social hatred, contentions, jealousies, outbursts of wrath, selfish ambitions, dissensions, heresies, envy, murders … “and the like”

Fruit of the Spirit — singular, grown
καρπός v.22

Upward love, joy, peace

Outward longsuffering, kindness, goodness

Inward faithfulness, gentleness, self-control

Love (ἀγάπη) comes first — self-sacrificing, the root of the rest

“Will not inherit the kingdom of God”

Galatians 5:21 · Outline III.A.2 — The danger of the works of the flesh

Not entering the kingdom

- Paul is writing to brethren — believers
- They have eternal life
- Entrance is promised and cannot be lost

But ruling with Christ in it

- Inheritance = reigning with Christ (Matt 19:29; Rev 2:26)
- Believers who live like unbelievers forfeit it
- Like Jacob's three sons in Genesis 49

When believers live like unbelievers, they will not rule with Christ in His righteous kingdom.

Participating in liberty

Galatians 5:24–26 · Outline IV

v.24	Provision — “those who are Christ's have crucified the flesh”	**ἐσταύρωσαν** aorist — a completed identification
v.16	Daily walking — ordinary, everyday conduct	**περιπατεῖτε** to walk around, conduct life
v.25	Power — “since we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit”	**στοιχῶμεν** march in rank, keep step
v.26	Particulars — not conceited, not provoking, not envying	**κενόδοξοι** “empty glory” — used only here

Don't try to live the Christian life without Him. You have the Holy Spirit from the moment you believed.

Discuss and apply

Galatians 5:13–26 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. What would it look like to “wash someone's feet” today — literally or figuratively — in your own relationships?

2. Which fruit of the Spirit do you most need to grow in right now, and what's one step toward depending on the Spirit for it?

Apply

Serve Through Love, Not License
Do one lowly, unglamorous task for someone this week — unasked, and without mentioning it.

Let the Root Produce the Fruit
Name the fruit you most need, and instead of resolving to try harder, spend time asking the Spirit for it.

In one line: Liberty is lived by walking in step with the Spirit, who grows what the law could only demand.